Theme 1

The evolution of human beings

Evolution means a gradual development. People like us, human beings, first appeared on earth about 200,000 years ago. Before human beings, there were other people, called **hominins,** living on earth. They were very similar to human beings. Hominins lived on earth for many thousands of years. Scientists think that human beings evolved from them.

There were different hominins on earth, who have been given various names. From the bones that have been found, artists have guessed what they may have looked like. Compare these pictures of two hominins and a human being, and read about them below, to understand the differences.

***Homo habilis*: They were small people and were the first to make and use stone tools. The tools were made by hitting one stone against another to give a sharp edge.**

***Homo erectus* (the upright man): Their stone tools were better made. They learnt to live so well with the environment that they survived on earth for about a million (1,000,000) years!**

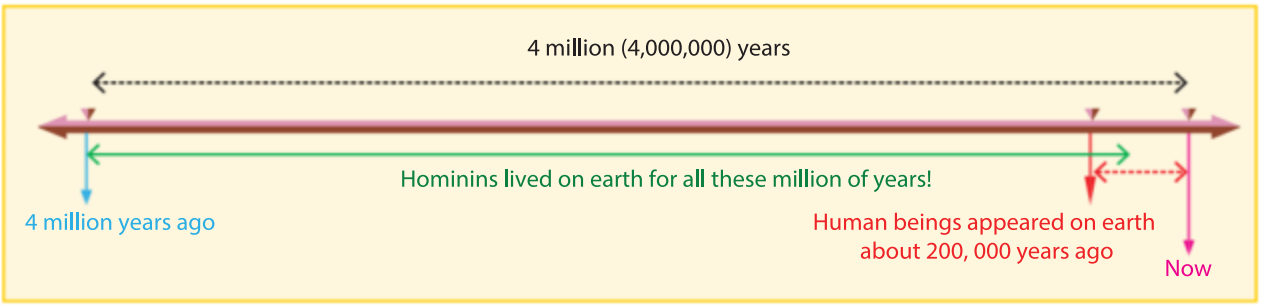
***Homo sapiens* (the thinking man) or human beings: We have been on earth for less time than the Homo erectus. In these thousands of years, we have learnt to use many different kinds of tools and weapons.**

Did you Know?

The earliest human remains have been found in Africa. This shows that human beings first appeared in Africa.

The timeline shows you:

- How long ago hominins probably appeared (blue arrow).
- When scientists think that human beings appeared (red arrow).
- How long hominins lived on earth. Some were probably still on earth when human beings first appeared (green arrow).
- How long human beings have been living on earth (dotted red arrow).
- Hominins lived on earth for much longer than human beings have been on earth (compare the green arrow with the dotted red arrow).



From various sources, experts know that early human beings learnt two important things from the hominins:

- How to hunt for food, using tools
- How useful fire was: that it could be used to cook food, that it kept them warm and that it kept them safe from wild animals who would not come near a fire

Early people discovered that fire was very useful.

In the next chapters you will learn about the earliest human beings and how, over many thousands of years, their way of life gradually evolved and became different.

Did you Know?

Remains in Africa, Europe and China make scientists think that the Homo erectus people were perhaps the first to use fire, though we do not know how they discovered it.